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LabStart Hiring Team

LabStart

RE: OPERATIONS ASSOCIATE

Dear LabStart Hiring Team,

I'm excited to apply for the Operations Associate role because this is the kind of work I genuinely enjoy: being the person behind the scenes who makes a small, ambitious team run better. Throughout my career, I've gravitated toward roles where I can spot what's broken, build a better system, get the details right, and document the process so it keeps working. **LabStart's need for someone to own the day-to-day mechanics while continuously improving how the organization operates feels like a particularly strong fit.**

I bring a strong combination of systems, operations, and technical experience. At Zayo Group, I owned Salesforce administration across CRM, Einstein, Marketing Cloud, data hygiene, automations, and reporting. At Lytics, I administered an enterprise customer data platform, supported data validation and reporting, and helped build the customer-delivery playbook and SOPs. I've spent much of my career translating messy processes into reliable systems — and I'm comfortable being the person who notices when the data, workflow, or process doesn't quite add up.

I also bring a strong instinct for automation. In my current work with an early-stage climate-tech startup, I've been building AI-assisted workflows using Claude Code, sub-agents, RAG pipelines, and prompt libraries to reduce repetitive work and help a small team operate more efficiently. I'd bring that same curiosity to LabStart: understand how work is actually getting done, identify the manual friction, and find practical ways to eliminate it.

The operational side of the role is equally familiar. I've worked in small startups and lean organizations where priorities change quickly and everyone wears multiple hats. I've managed inventory and vendor relationships, improved receiving and reconciliation processes, coordinated community events, built internal documentation, supported hiring and onboarding, and kept technology stacks running for small teams. Earlier in my career, I worked with mission-driven organizations including the Humanitarian OpenStreetMap Team and Cadasta, which gave me an early appreciation for the resourcefulness and ownership required in small nonprofits.

I also have an MBA and am comfortable working with budgets, expenses, reporting, and the details behind financial operations. More broadly, I'm a highly organized, systems-oriented person who enjoys the combination of independent execution and figuring things out as I go. I'm comfortable learning a new tool quickly, chasing down a stalled task, coordinating across competing priorities, or simply taking something off a teammate's plate because it needs to get done.

Most importantly, LabStart's mission resonates with me. Climate and environmental work has been a consistent thread throughout my career, from geospatial and humanitarian mapping to environmental technology and, most recently, building a climate-tech startup focused on water operations. I'm particularly excited by LabStart's model of helping turn promising climate technologies into real companies and supporting entrepreneurs through that process.

I'd be excited to bring my systems mindset, startup experience, and genuine enthusiasm for climate technology to the LabStart team. I'm also very open to Salida — I already have close friends there, so relocating would feel much more like returning to a community than starting somewhere entirely new.

Thank you for considering my application. I'd love the opportunity to talk.

Best,

Katrina Engelsted

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